Association Between Early Adversity and the Timing of the Transition to Parenthood

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BACKGROUND

- The transition to parenthood is one of the most salient developmental changes in young adulthood.
- Although the current national average for the age at first childbirth is around 25 years old, there is marked variability in when this occurs (Mathews & Hamilton, 2009).
  - For example, 20% of women have their first child before the age of 20 and nearly 10% of women have their first child after the age of 35.
- The timing of when this transition occurs is associated with later adversity for both the parent and their child.
  - Earlier age of parenthood is associated with increased risk for mental health issues (e.g. depression), poor romantic relationship quality, and lower educational and work attainment (Jaffee, 2002).
  - Children of younger parents are at heightened risk for poorer developmental outcomes (Pogarsky, Thornberry, & Lizotte, 2006).
  - Research on the determinants of the variability in the timing of the transition to parenthood has traditionally focused on concurrent factors (Jaffee et al., 2006).
- However, far less is known about the developmental antecedents of the timing of the transition to parenthood.

PURPOSE

The purpose of this longitudinal study was to investigate the developmental antecedents of the timing of the transition to parenthood in a mixed gender sample at risk for poor developmental outcomes.

HYPOTHESES

1. There will be a direct association between timing of the transition to parenthood and early experiences of demographic risk.

2. Parenting quality will mediate this association.

METHODS

- Measures of demographic risk were collected at the time of the child's birth 181 individuals (male = 96).
  - This included (1) mothers' age, (2) mothers' education, (3) mothers' race, and (4) mothers' marital status.
  - These four factors were dichotomized and summed to form a cumulative risk score for each individual.
- Parenting quality was assessed across the first five years of the child's life.
  - Mothers' parenting quality was observed when their child was both 24 and 42 months.
  - Emotional support provided to the child by the biological father was rated from interviews with the mothers.
- In a follow-up assessment with the individuals at age 34, information regarding parental status and age of first childbirth was collected.

RESULTS

Table 1. *Descriptive Information for Focal Variables.*

Variables	M	SD	Frequency 0	Frequency 1
Demographic Risk				
Maternal age	20.7	3.75	…	…
Maternal marriage status	…	…	114	67
Maternal educational attainment	11.89	1.82	…	…
Maternal ethnic minority status	…	…	149	32
Cumulative demographic risk	1.61	1.25	…	…
Relationship Process				
Maternal Parenting Quality (24 months)	0.05	0.81	…	…
Maternal Parenting Quality (42 months)	0.00	0.81	…	…
Early Paternal Support	2.16	1.81	…	…
Outcome Variables				
Parenting Status (age 34)	…	…	41	140
Timing of Transition to Parenthood	23.74	4.78	…	…

Direct Associations

- The *presence* of early risk was associated with a lower age of first childbirth.
- Maternal parenting quality experienced when the children were toddlers as well as the support provided by the biological father significantly predicted the subsequent timing of their transition to parenthood.

Table 2. *Associations Between Demographic Risk and Parenting Quality as Predictors of the Timing of the Transition to Parenthood.*

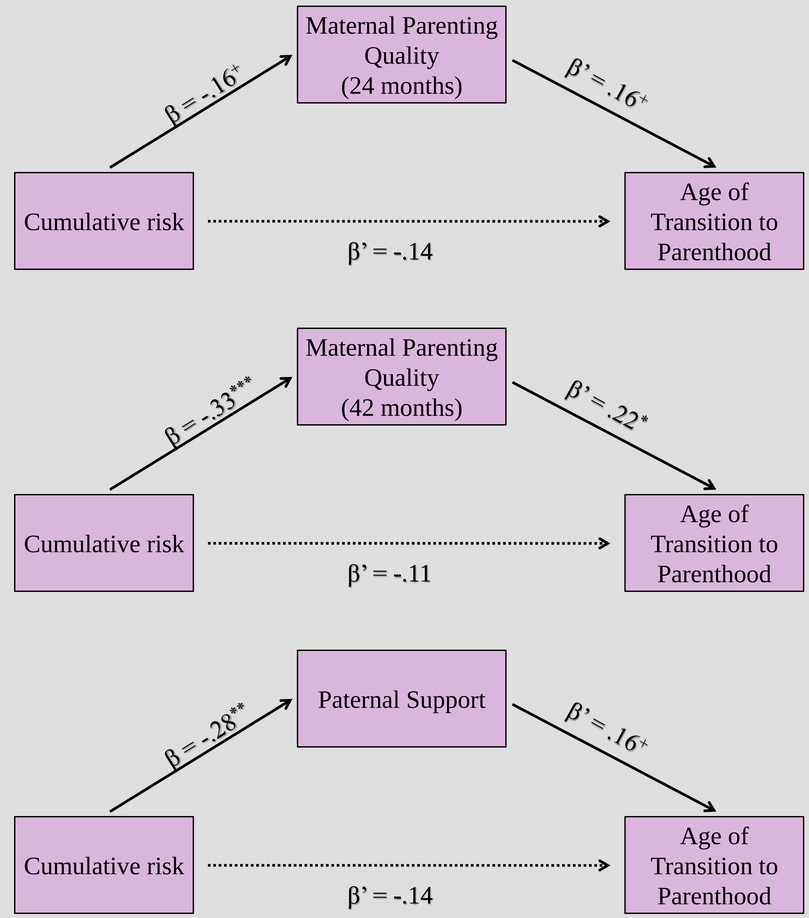
	Age of Transition to Parenthood	
	B	*SE*
Demographic Risk		
Maternal Age	0.17	0.11
Maternal Ethnic Minority Status	-2.85**	0.94
Maternal Marital Status	0.84	0.86
Maternal Education	0.55*	0.22
Cumulative Demographic Risk	-0.80*	0.32
Parenting Quality		
Maternal Parenting Quality at 24 months	1.08*	0.51
Maternal Parenting Quality at 42 months	1.48**	0.48
Early Paternal Support	0.55*	0.24

Note: $^{+}$ $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$.

Mediation

- When cumulative risk and parenting quality were simultaneously entered as predictors of the timing of the transition to parenthood, cumulative risk was no longer a significant predictor.
- In all three cases, parenting quality measures were still at least marginally significant predictors.
- Sobel's test indicated that maternal parenting at 42 months was a significant mediator ($p = .01$) and paternal support was a marginally significant mediator ($p = .06$) of the link between cumulative risk and the timing of the transition to parenthood.

Figure 1. Model describing the hypothesized relationship between cumulative risk and the age of the transition to parenthood as mediated by (A) maternal parenting quality at 24 months, (B) maternal parenting quality at 42 months, and (C) paternal support.



DISCUSSION

- The timing of the transition to parenthood was predicted by measures of demographic risk and parenting quality, both collected over 3 decades earlier.
- There was moderate evidence that parenting quality provided by mothers and fathers mediated the association between cumulative risk and the timing of the transition to parenthood.
  - Suggests that demographic risks exert their influence by impacting adults' parenting quality, which in turn affects the child's eventual decisions about when to have children.
- These findings suggest a role for the timing of the transition to parenthood in the intergenerational transmission of adversity.

- **Implications:** Interventions that target parenting quality early in the child's life may show benefits across generations.